

Tubelights and CFC bulbs, for example, have a high colour temperature, with the light being a little blue. Candlelight or a tungsten bulb or a street lamp have a slightly lower temperature and tend to reflect with a tint of orange. Outdoors on a bright sunny day have a very high temperature, also with an orangish light. The tint of the lighting conditions under which the photo was taken influences the photo, if the correct white balance is not used. The most common mistake because of this are photos like these, which are taken indoors under fluorescent lighting without using the correct white balance.



Incorrect white balance (left) Correct white balance (right)

The white balance setting shifts all the colours in the image sensor according to the source light colour temperature. A proper white balance essentially ensures that the colour white shows up as being white in the photograph. Any photo with some white element in it allows the camera to accurately and automatically set a white balance for the picture. Using white balance on auto all the time does not really work. Most digital cameras have white balance settings based on available illumination. These include cloudy skies, tungsten light, fluorescent light, daylight and flash. Some cameras may use a term known as “Kelvin” to adjust the white balance. Here is a rough idea of the temperature of commonly encountered light sources.

0 W bulbs, candles	–	1000 Kelvin
Tungsten bulb/sunrise/sunset	–	3500 Kelvin
Tube lights/fluorescent lights	–	4500 Kelvin
Flash	–	5000 Kelvin
Sunlight	–	6500 Kelvin
Cloudy sky	–	8000 Kelvin